

States that depend on a powerful patron for their security do not always have the luxury of saying what they think. Formal diplomatic channels—UN votes, official statements, public breaks—become liabilities when they risk retaliation from the very power that guarantees a state's survival. Yet silence risks being seen as endorsement. This dilemma arises in any hierarchical relationship where a subordinate depends on a patron but must also maintain relationships with other audiences.

The Russian invasion of Ukraine confronted Russia's formal security partners with exactly this bind. States bound to Russia through CSTO and bilateral agreements had genuine reasons to oppose the invasion—it violated sovereignty norms and threatened economic ties with the West—but open condemnation of a patron willing to use force in its near abroad was not viable. We argue that state-owned media functions as an informal signaling channel through which constrained states communicate preferences to external audiences. While IR scholarship has treated state media as a domestic tool Western governments have long monitored it for signals of regime preferences. The credibility of this channel rests on three features: external observers understand state outlets to be under government control, so shifts in coverage are read as regime choices; the signal is costly, since negative coverage of a security patron risks retaliation; and crucially, the signal can reach Western intelligence audiences while operating below the visibility threshold likely to provoke the patron.

Why state media rather than other channels? The most public instruments—UN votes, formal statements—are too costly for states bound by security agreements. Private diplomacy avoids provocation but sacrifices credibility, since messages behind closed doors are unverifiable (Fearon, 1997). State-owned media occupies the middle ground: public enough to be observed by foreign governments, yet quiet enough to stay below the patron's response threshold.

We test this argument across twelve states in Russia's near abroad, drawing on 174,000 newspaper articles. We measure article-level sentiment toward Russia using GPT-4o ($F1=.92$ vs. human coders) and exploit the sharp discontinuity of February 24 in a Difference-in-Discontinuity design.

We first establish that the invasion produced a negative shock to media sentiment across the region, then show this decline was not uniform: independent media responded more negatively than state-owned media, consistent with strategic management of coverage. The critical test compares across security relationships. A domestic audience management account predicts Russia-aligned states suppress negative coverage. Instead, state-owned media in Russian-allied states shifted more negatively than in neutral states, despite these states refusing to condemn the invasion formally—consistent with

constrained states using media to signal dissatisfaction because formal channels were unavailable.

Understanding how constrained allies respond to patron aggression matters for assessing alliance cohesion during conflict, yet formal diplomatic behavior obscures these preferences. Our findings show that state media offers a legible window into what formal channels conceal—demonstrating that the signals practitioners have long tracked are theoretically structured and empirically identifiable, and that the role of media in conflict extends beyond domestic audience management to international signaling under constraint.